



## MONTHLY UPDATE

# Burundi: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-29 • 29 systems and instruments tracked

*Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • INCLUSION

## Summary of the month

Two things in this period bear on everything else Burundi is building. The regulator [conceded on 3 August 2026 that internet quality is degraded and set out six causes, four of them electricity](#). And an [access-to-information bill was listed on the National Assembly's order paper for the session opened the day before](#), the first dated marker the base holds for it. In between, the consumer association reported that the regulator's [own injunctions on consent had changed nothing](#), the civil-service ministry [published its own list of what its reform has not delivered](#), and the [first documented AI-governance workshop was run by an alumni association, not a regulator](#).

## Governance

### Legislation and regulation

An [access-to-information bill is on the National Assembly's order paper for the session opened at the Kigobe Congress Palace on 3 August 2026](#). The first vice-president listed it among the bills the chamber will examine. Article 176 caps ordinary sessions at three months, putting the outer bound for passage in this sitting at roughly end-October 2026. No text, tabling number, sponsoring ministry or timetable was published and no copy is held – the announcement establishes only that the bill exists and is scheduled. Burundi has had no access-to-information statute on file to date.

The ministry opened consultations on the country's first dedicated framework for online publishing. A workshop on 26 August [gathered influencers, content creators, legal experts and jurists for sector input before a bill regulating social-media influencers and content creators is finalised](#); no draft provisions are published, and whether the law would require registration, set disclosure rules for sponsored content, create an oversight body or set penalties is unestablished.

### Data protection

On 24 July the consumer association ABUCO [told Iwacu that months of complaints describe subscribers enrolled in paid value-added services without their knowledge and with no notification](#), some losing 3,000 to 10,000 Burundian francs a day; [its president cites over 40,000 francs taken as such charges across about three months from November 2025](#). ARCT issued injunctions to Lumitel on 29 May 2026 requiring genuinely voluntary subscription and prior notification; Lumitel maintains nothing activates without a customer's deliberate action; ABUCO reports no significant improvement since, and no sanction is on file. The new data-protection law's central mechanism is consent, and no role for the authority it creates is reported here.

## Regional collaboration

Vietnam's science and technology ministry [received Burundi's governing-party secretary-general on 28 July 2026 and pressed for faster implementation of the November 2024 memorandum](#). The channel runs through the party rather than the ministry. Vietnam asked Burundi to create conditions for Lumitel, its own operator's subsidiary, to contribute more; Burundi named postal-system modernisation and internet infrastructure as its priorities. No monetary commitment was announced.

## Public debate and participation in policymaking

ABUCO's [same 28 July statement](#) proposed a convening — états généraux bringing public authorities, operators, regulators and consumer organisations into one forum — as its remedy, the only instrument a consumer body can reach for; no response from government or operators is on file, and no convening date is stated.

## ICT Infrastructure

### Connectivity

On 3 August the regulator ARCT [accepted that internet quality is degraded and named the causes](#): recurrent electricity cuts forcing base stations and data centres onto generators the operators struggle to fuel, unstable supply from the utility REGIDESO, bandwidth saturation in urban centres, ageing transmission equipment and simple absence of masts in parts of the country. It said it can apply the sanctions in operators' licence conditions, and named two remedies: a draft law enabling ICT infrastructure sharing and a PAFEN-financed mast-deployment programme. Lumitel and Econet Leo were contacted for that account and did not respond.

On the money side, the universal service fund's [revised FY2026/27 procurement plan carries BIF 11.40bn for dedicated IP transit](#) — 8 Mbit to public health facilities and 10 Mbit to schools — funded from the 1% levy on operator turnover rather than from the general budget.

### Energy

Among the regulator's remedies for degraded service, named [on 3 August](#), is a planned study on powering mobile base stations.

### Cybersecurity

EAC central bank governors, meeting in July 2026 as the Monetary Affairs Committee, [flagged cybersecurity risk to the regional financial system as requiring stronger common measures](#), with no common measure yet adopted.

## DPI

### Digital Identity and CRVS

Biometric civil registration is [operating in 13 pilot communes, decentralised to zone level and interoperable with health-facility birth and death records, with a national unique identifier planned on fingerprint and facial biometrics](#). The health-facility link is the part with numbers behind it: the interior ministry says it has been [piloted since 2023, institutionalised in 2024, and now runs in 123 health facilities where it has recorded more than 52,000 births](#). No coverage denominator is given for either figure.

It is being built onto a base that already reaches most children: [84% of under-fives are registered at birth and 66% hold a birth certificate](#), cited by government on Africa Civil Registration Day. The gap between the two figures is the one the platform has to close.

## Digital Payments and Fintech

The same EAC central bank governors [agreed to accelerate the East African Monetary Union roadmap and welcomed progress on the Regional Cross-Border Payment System Master Plan](#). On their own account the plan's first activities are work plans and resource mobilisation — design, not deployment.

## Sectoral management information systems

The one new management system in the window sits outside the state's own stack. A [digital tool for tracking the institutional performance of Burundi's technical and vocational training centres in real time was validated on 7 August](#), built by CREOP-Jeunes under the EU-backed Umwuga Akazi project. No deployment date, centre count or custodian ministry is stated, so what the tool will be attached to is not yet on the record.

## Other GovTech and e-Gov

The civil-service ministry [put a set of digitisation claims on the record on 31 July and published the constraints against them](#), which is the more useful half. The programme covers performance evaluation of public agents, a job-classification scheme, an annual costed work plan used across public institutions, progressive interconnection of administrative services, and one-stop service desks. The ministry itself names archive management as still largely manual, service digitisation as unfinished and working tools as insufficient. Citizens interviewed framed digitisation as a distance problem: fewer journeys for people living far from administrative centres.

## Technology

### AI

Burundi's first documented AI-governance discussion took place in the professional community, not government. A [two-day workshop in Bujumbura on 27 July 2026, organised by the association of Burundian alumni of the German Academic Exchange Service](#), drew doctors, IT specialists, students and developers. The load-bearing statement came from the director-general of the Muganga Innovation Lab: Burundi has recently legislated on personal-data protection but holds a great deal of information and relatively little of it as structured, consented, usable data — the constraint that makes fairness and traceability arguments premature, and one no AI strategy addresses. Sessions covered AI ethics and labour displacement, AI for resource governance, UNESCO and ISO frameworks, and data governance for connected devices.

### Innovation ecosystem

The workshop's resource-governance session named the [MineGuard mining-intelligence platform](#), and AfriPrompt was the other local build named — two builds with no funding, user base or public deployment on file.

## Capacity

### Training and skills

Vietnam reports that what it has delivered under the November 2024 memorandum is [policy transfer rather than build: drafting experience, reference materials supplied to Burundian agencies, 50 desktop computer sets, and Master's scholarships in computer science](#).

### Research institutions

The research capacity the AI strategy assumes showed itself once this month, [outside the state](#).

## Inclusion

### Access to services

ABUCO's [statement of 28 July 2026](#) is the month's one dated position on affordability: internet package tariffs have more than doubled since the January 2025 instruction to operators to improve service, while quality fell, and it runs against the service obligations that instruction set. Its president describes the sector as having returned to the situation of the early 2000s and names businesses, traders and public administrations among those affected. The two sources on file attribute that instruction differently, one to the telecommunications ministry and one to the interior minister; no text of it is held.

### Digital divides

The telecommunications regulator told a workshop that very few Burundians use the internet. It characterised the level without publishing a figure, so the finding the base can carry is the regulator's own [statement that use is low](#), not a percentage.

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